

FREE DOWNLOAD

How to Choose Your Senior Portrait Photographer.

A practical guide for seniors and their families.

What to look for — and what actually matters.

Questions to ask before you book.

Red flags that should make you walk away.

How to understand pricing and what's included.

The portfolio test — how to look at work critically.

The Austin session — what's different here.

Why Nydam Photography.

WELCOME

How to Choose Someone Who Gets It Right.

A guide for seniors
and their families.

“Eighteen years. Hundreds of families. The one thing we know for certain: the right photographer doesn’t just capture your image — they earn your trust first.”

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

Austin, Texas · Est. 2008

Most seniors spend more time choosing their outfit than choosing their photographer. That’s backwards. The photographer determines everything — the direction, the quality, the experience, and the images you’ll have for the rest of your life.

This guide gives you the exact framework we’d give any senior in our family. What to look for, what to ask, what to walk away from. Use it for any photographer — including us.

The right senior portrait photographer isn’t just someone with a good camera. They have a process. They direct. They communicate. They’ve earned their reputation over years, not just on Instagram.

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NP SENIORS — ALL-INCLUSIVE

Hair & makeup included. You show up. We handle everything.

01

What to Look For.

Not every photographer with a great Instagram is a great photographer. These are the qualities that actually matter — and why each one changes the quality of your images.

QUALITIES THAT MATTER MOST

- + **They direct posing — actively.**
A photographer who says “just be natural” has no posing process. Every frame should be guided. You should never be left guessing where to put your hands.
- + **They shoot with flash outdoors.**
Natural light is beautiful. But Austin midday sun is brutal. A photographer who uses off-camera flash outdoors has the technical skill to make you look great in any conditions, not just perfect golden hour.
- + **They have a process — not just a camera.**
Pre-session communication, wardrobe review, location planning. A professional shows up prepared. A hobbyist shows up and figures it out.
- + **Their portfolio shows range.**
Multiple locations, multiple skin tones, multiple lighting conditions. If every photo looks the same, they have one trick. Great photographers adapt.

WHAT SEPARATES GOOD FROM GREAT

- + **Experience you can verify.**
How many years? How many sessions? Can you see a full gallery — not just highlights? Eighteen years means thousands of sessions and every situation imaginable.
- + **They know Austin’s light.**
Texas summer sun, golden hour in October, the flat midday light of spring. A local photographer knows exactly where to position you, when to shoot, and how to make the location work for you.
- + **You feel directed, not posed.**
The best senior sessions don’t feel like photoshoots. They feel like a great afternoon with someone who knows exactly how to bring out the best in you.
- + **They communicate before the session.**
A pre-session consultation, a wardrobe review, a location plan. If your photographer doesn’t ask about you before the session, they’re not preparing for you.

THE SINGLE BEST QUESTION TO ASK

Can I see a full session gallery — not just your portfolio?

A curated portfolio shows their best 20 images. A full gallery shows their skill level. Ask to see 30–50 images from one client session. That’s where you see consistency.

02 Questions to Ask.

Ask these before you book anyone. The quality of their answers will tell you everything about their process, their professionalism, and whether they're the right fit.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

+ Do you shoot with flash outdoors?

The answer should be yes — or at minimum, yes when conditions call for it. Flash control outdoors separates technical photographers from natural-light-only shooters.

+ How do you direct posing?

They should describe a clear posing process. “I give direction throughout” is good. “I let you be natural” is a red flag. You want someone who guides every frame.

+ Is hair and makeup included?

Know exactly what's in the package before you commit. Some studios include it. Some charge separately. The NP Seniors 2027 all-inclusive experience covers everything.

+ Can I see a full session gallery?

Ask for 30–50 images from one complete client session — not their best portfolio shots. Full galleries reveal consistency, range, and whether their work holds up start to finish.

+ What's your retouching style?

Ask to see before-and-afters. Heavy skin smoothing, trendy color grades, and body alterations age badly. You want retouching that enhances, not transforms.

ABOUT THE SESSION

+ What happens if it rains?

A professional has a rescheduling policy and a rain plan. If they haven't thought about it, they haven't done enough sessions. Ask for their policy in writing.

+ How many outfits can I bring?

Know the session structure before you arrive. Three to four looks is standard for a full session. Understand how outfit changes are built into the timeline.

+ How soon is the gallery delivered?

Industry standard is two to four weeks. Significantly longer is a red flag. Ask if there's a rush option and whether the gallery is downloadable or delivered on USB.

+ What's included — files, prints, or both?

Understand exactly what you receive. High-resolution digital files? Print credit? In-person ordering appointment? Get the full picture before you sign anything.

+ Do you do a pre-session consultation?

The best sessions are planned. A pre-session conversation about your style, locations, and outfits is a sign of a photographer who takes preparation seriously.

RED FLAGS

Red Flags.

These aren't minor issues. Each one is a sign of an inexperienced, unprepared, or unprofessional photographer. If you see more than one — walk away.

WATCH FOR THESE

- + **“Just be yourself” — zero posing direction.**
If their direction begins and ends there, your images will show it. Posing is a skill that takes years to develop. You deserve a photographer who has it.
- + **Only Instagram as a portfolio.**
A feed is curated to show highlights. A real photographer has full galleries, a website, and a booking process. An Instagram page alone is not a business.
- + **No contract and no retainer.**
This means no legal protection for you and no commitment from them. Professional photographers have contracts. Always. Without exception.
- + **Pricing that seems too low.**
A \$150 senior session is either a new photographer building a portfolio or someone who will deliver 10 mediocre images and disappear. You get what you pay for.

THE STORIES YOU'LL HEAR

- + **“They never told me what to do with my hands.”**
Posing direction is the photographer's job. If you felt lost, they weren't doing it.
- + **“The photos came back two months later.”**
Delivery timelines should be stated in the contract. Two to four weeks is professional. Months later is unacceptable.
- + **“The editing was heavy and it doesn't look like me.”**
Over-processing, skin smoothing, and trendy color grades feel exciting at 17 and look dated at 25. Always ask to see unedited samples alongside edited ones.
- + **“I thought flash was included — it wasn't.”**
Natural-light-only photographers have real limitations in Austin's conditions. Off-camera flash outdoors is a technical skill that takes years to master.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Trust your gut. If the booking process feels unprofessional — the session will too.

A great photographer makes every part of the experience feel taken care of: the inquiry, the contract, the prep call, the session, the delivery. Every step reflects their standard of work.

04

Understanding Pricing.

Price reflects experience, equipment, time, and process. Understanding what you're actually paying for makes every comparison fair — and helps you avoid the trap of choosing on price alone.

WHAT YOU'RE ACTUALLY PAYING FOR

+ The photographer's time and skill.

A two-hour senior session involves two hours on location, one to two hours of culling, and two to four hours of editing. You're paying for six-plus hours of professional work.

+ Equipment investment.

Professional camera bodies, lenses, and off-camera flash systems represent tens of thousands of dollars. That equipment is what makes your images look the way they do.

+ Years of practice.

A photographer with 18 years and thousands of sessions has refined every element of their process. That experience is reflected in the price — and in the quality of your images.

+ The full delivery.

High-resolution digital files, professional retouching, gallery hosting, and ordering options. Know exactly what format your images come in and for how long they're accessible.

THE ALL-INCLUSIVE MODEL

+ No surprises at delivery.

All-inclusive means everything is covered upfront: session time, hair and makeup, direction, editing, and digital delivery. One price. No add-ons. No awkward upsells.

+ Hair and makeup handled.

Professional styling at the session eliminates one of the biggest stressors of session day. You arrive, you sit down, you get taken care of. Then we shoot.

+ The true cost of "cheap."

A \$200 session that delivers 15 mediocre images is more expensive than a \$500 session that delivers 80 images you'll use forever. Price per image matters.

+ Investment vs. expense.

Senior portraits are made once. The images are with you forever. The cost of the right photographer, amortized over 20 years of display and use, is the smallest line item in the whole experience.

NP SENIORS 2027 · ALL-INCLUSIVE

Professional hair, makeup & styling included. No add-ons. No surprises.

Everything from the pre-session consultation to the final gallery delivery is handled. You show up. We take care of the rest. nydamphoto.com

THE PORTFOLIO TEST

The Portfolio Test.

A portfolio is a photographer's best argument for themselves. Here's how to evaluate it critically — so you see skill level, not just a beautiful feed.

HOW TO LOOK AT A PORTFOLIO

+ Start with the eyes.

Every portrait lives or dies on the eyes. Are they sharp, expressive, and well-lit? If the eyes in a portfolio aren't consistently excellent, the rest doesn't matter.

+ Look for range in skin tones and lighting.

A portfolio with only one type of subject in perfect golden hour is not proof of skill. Can they expose correctly for darker skin tones? Do they handle harsh midday light well?

+ Check posing variety.

Do all the subjects look roughly the same? Are there genuine expressions, or is everyone giving the same "serious editorial" look? Range is everything.

+ Is the editing consistent?

Wild variation in color grade between images means inconsistent skills or over-reliance on presets. Great editing is nearly invisible — it enhances without calling attention to itself.

THE INSTAGRAM PROBLEM

+ A feed is not a portfolio.

Instagram shows 9 to 12 curated images at a glance. Ask to see a full session gallery — 30 to 50 images from a single client. That's where real skill becomes visible.

+ Ask for midday sun images.

Golden hour forgives everything. Midday sun reveals technical skill. If a photographer only posts magic-hour images, ask to see what they do at noon.

+ Look for subjects who look like you.

If the entire portfolio shows one body type, one skin tone, one style, ask yourself whether they have experience with clients who look like you — and whether it shows.

+ Consistency beats a single great image.

One incredible photo can be lucky. Thirty consistently excellent images across a single session is skill. Ask for the full session — every time.

THE TWO-WORD TEST

Look at the portfolio and ask: does this person look like themselves?

The best senior portraits don't look like editorial shoots or Instagram content. They look like a real person on their absolute best day. That's the standard.

06

The Austin Session.

Austin is a different environment. The heat is real, the light is specific, and the season matters more here than almost anywhere else. Your photographer needs to know this city to work in it well.

WHAT'S DIFFERENT HERE

+ Flash is non-negotiable in Texas sun.

Midday Austin light creates harsh shadows, blown highlights, and flat color. A photographer who uses off-camera flash outdoors can make your images look great in any light — not just the hour before sunset.

+ Golden hour timing.

Summer sessions at 7 to 8pm are extraordinary. The light is warm, soft, and forgiving. Spring sessions in the afternoon are stunning with blooming wildflowers. Know your photographer's preferred timing — and trust it.

+ Heat management matters.

A photographer who has worked Austin summers knows how to keep you comfortable, manage sweat and shine, pace the session around the heat, and choose locations with available shade. Local experience makes this seamless.

+ The best season is fall.

September through November is Austin's most popular season for senior portraits — and for good reason. The light is extraordinary, temperatures are manageable, and the color palette is stunning. Book early.

LOCATIONS & PLANNING

+ Urban downtown sessions.

South Congress, East 6th, Mueller, The Domain — structured, editorial, bold. Brick walls, murals, doorways, and architecture give you natural framing at every turn. Perfect for editorial-style portraits.

+ Natural locations.

Barton Creek Greenbelt, Blunn Creek, McKinney Falls, Pease Park. Wildflowers in spring, warm light year-round, and the natural beauty that makes Austin different from any other Texas city.

+ Suburban Austin.

Hutto, Taylor, Manor, Georgetown, Round Rock — all offer unique settings and are increasingly popular for families and seniors who want something different from downtown urban looks.

+ Your location should match your outfits.

Urban sessions call for structured, editorial looks. Natural locations work with flowy dresses and earthy tones. Mixed sessions: plan one look per environment and let your photographer build the flow around it.

07

Why Nydam Photography.

Run every criterion in this guide against us. We expect to meet every one. Here's exactly what we bring to every NP Seniors session — no additions required.

WHAT A GREAT SESSION LOOKS LIKE

- + **18 years. Thousands of sessions.**
We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every situation you can imagine — we've navigated it.
- + **Flash and natural light — every session.**
We shoot with both, always. Natural light for warmth. Off-camera flash for control. The result is images that look great in any condition, any time of day.
- + **We direct everything.**
Where to stand, where to look, what to do with your hands. You will never be left guessing. Posing is our responsibility — and we take it seriously every frame.
- + **Preparation before the session.**
A pre-session consultation, wardrobe review, and location plan signal a professional. If a photographer doesn't ask about you before the session, they aren't preparing for you.

NP SENIORS 2027 · ALL-INCLUSIVE

- + **Professional hair and makeup included.**
You arrive and get taken care of from the first minute. Professional styling is built into the session experience — not an add-on, not an option. Standard.
- + **Multiple looks, planned in advance.**
Three to four outfits give you real variety. A good photographer builds the session timeline around your looks — not the other way around. Ask how outfit changes are handled.
- + **Clear delivery. No hidden costs.**
High-resolution files, professional retouching, and a clear gallery delivery process with no surprise upsells. Know exactly what you're receiving before you book.
- + **Genuine. Intentional. Timeless.**
Our editing is clean, consistent, and designed to look as good in ten years as it does today. No heavy filters. No trends. Just your images — at their best.

READY TO BOOK?

"Genuine. Intentional. Timeless." · Nydam Photography, Austin TX

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About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceñeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding
Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us.

The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift.

A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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